DA Quick Cards

The everyday jobs, one card each, in a few steps. Print them (the **PDF version** button above) and keep them by the computer. The full user guide explains everything else.

My archive (fill this in when DA is set up):

My archive	**(write it here)**
My archives are in	
New photos and papers go to the archive	
My backup drive is	
For help, call or text	

Your desktop shortcuts

Each job starts with a double-click on a shortcut, so you never have to find a folder or type a command. A shortcut is just a door into a folder or a job: deleting a shortcut deletes nothing else. The cards use these:

Shortcut	What it opens
Open DA	DA's menu, in your newest archive
New photos	The folder new photos go in
New papers	The folder new papers and scans go in
Archives	All your archives, to look at photos and papers
Back up archives	Copies everything to the backup drive

Card 1: Add photos from a phone or camera

1. Plug in the phone or camera (or put its memory card in the computer).
2. Double-click **New photos**.
3. Make a folder named for what happened: right-click an empty spot, **New > Folder**, and type a name like `Beach trip` or `Emma's birthday`. No date needed: DA adds it.
4. Copy the photos from the phone or camera into that folder.
5. Double-click **Open DA**, type **1** and press **Enter**.
6. Wait. DA is done when it shows **Where things stand now**.

Your photos are now in the year, in a folder like `2026-06 Beach trip`. Copies of photos you already had are set aside, not filed twice. Keep the photos on the phone until after the next backup (Card 6).

Before step 4, you can pick a better moment for an iPhone Live Photo (Card 1b). Between steps 4 and 5, you can delete the shots you don't want (Card 1c).

Card 1b: Change the key photo in an iPhone Live Photo

The *key photo* is the moment a Live Photo shows. Pick a better one (eyes open, smiling) on the iPhone, **before** copying the photos (Card 1).

1. In **Photos**, tap the Live Photo (**LIVE** at the top left), then **Edit**.
2. Tap **Live** (the round icon at the bottom).
3. Slide the white frame along the strip to the moment you want.
4. Tap **Make Key Photo**, then **Done**. (**Edit**, **Revert** undoes it.)

In **New photos** you'll see `IMG_1234` (as taken, with its video) and `IMG_E1234` (the new key photo). **Keep both:** DA files them side by side.

Card 1c: Clean up camera photos before filing

After copying into **New photos** and **before pressing 1** (Card 1): nothing is filed yet, so it's safe.

1. Double-click **New photos** and open the folder you just made.
2. Click **View**, then **Large icons**, to see the pictures.
3. Click a shot you don't want: blurry, a finger on the lens, taken by mistake, or one of many alike. Hold **Ctrl** and click to pick more.
4. Press **Delete**. They go to the **Recycle Bin**, so you can still get them back.
5. Carry on with Card 1, step 5.

Files with the same name go together: delete both or neither (`IMG_1234.HEIC` and its video `IMG_1234.MOV`; `IMG_0574.JPG` and its RAW `IMG_0574.CR2`).

Only in New photos, never in **Archives** (Card 7). Copies you already have need no deleting: DA sets them aside.

Card 2: Add papers and scans

1. Scan the papers, or save the PDF (a bill, a statement), into **New papers**. Several at once is fine.
2. Double-click **Open DA**, type **1** and press **Enter**.
3. Wait for **Where things stand now**.

DA files each paper by the date printed on it, in a folder for its year and month.

Card 3: Name the events in a month

For photos already filed that sit together in one month's folder.

1. Double-click **Open DA**, type **L** and press **Enter**.
2. DA lists the months. Type the number of the month and press **Enter**.
3. DA shows the photos in groups, a group for each outing or day. For each group:
   - press **Enter** to take the name shown,
   - or type a better name, like `Grandma's 80th`, and press **Enter**,
   - or type **-** and press **Enter** to leave that group where it is.
4. Give two groups the **same name** to put them in one folder.
5. Press **Enter** when DA asks to move them.

Card 3b: Date old photos

For scanned prints and other photos DA couldn't date: they wait in **review**, a folder at a time.

1. Double-click **Open DA**, type **V** and press **Enter**. The **Dates** page opens in the browser.
2. Pick a folder at the top. Click the photos that were taken together (they get a tick).
3. The big date shows DA's best guess. Press **−** or **+** to go a month older or newer, **−−** or **++** for a year. Or click the date and type it, like `1987-03`.
4. Press **Set**. The photos show **dated** in green.
5. Do the next photos. Made a mistake? Press **Undo**.
6. When you're done, press **File dated photos** (or type **1** in DA next time).

A month is enough. If you only know the year, set it anyway: the photo waits until you know the month.

Card 4: Look at photos and papers

1. Double-click **Archives**.
2. Open the archive for the years you want: the one ending **201x** holds 2010 to 2019.
3. Open **photos**, then **organized**, then the year, then the month or event.
4. Double-click a photo to see it. Each folder also has a **_contact-sheet.pdf**: the whole folder on a few pages, to find the photo you're after quickly.

Papers are in the same archive, under **documents**, then **organized**, then the year.

To look in a web browser instead: double-click **Open DA**, type **B** and press **Enter**.

Card 5: Find something

1. Double-click **Archives**.
2. Click in the **Search** box at the top right of the window.
3. Type a word from the event or the paper: `Beach`, `2019`, `birthday`, `Water Company`.
4. Wait a moment for the list, then double-click what you want.

Card 6: Back up (once a week)

1. Plug in the backup drive.
2. Double-click **Back up archives**.
3. Wait. The first time takes a long while; after that, only what changed is copied.
4. When it says **You can unplug the backup drive**, press any key, then unplug it.
5. Put the backup drive away from the computer.

If it says **The backup drive isn't there**, plug it in and try again. If it says anything else, don't try again: call for help.

Card 7: When something looks wrong

1. **Stop.** Don't move, rename or delete anything in the archive folders yourself.
2. Take a photo of the screen with your phone, or write down what it says.
3. Call or text for help (the number is on the first page).

Nothing is lost. DA never deletes your photos or papers: copies are only set aside, and everything DA moves can be put back. Your helper can see your screen from their home: in Windows, click **Start**, type **Quick Assist**, and read them the code it shows.

For the helper: setting up a computer

Once per computer, with DA installed (see *Getting started* in the user guide):

1. **Archives:** `da setup <folder>` for each decade, e.g. `D:\archives\jane-archive-202x --years 2020-2029`.
2. **Old drives:** in each archive, `da import <drives> --apply`, most complete first, then **1 Autorun** and **S Split by years**.
3. **No questions:** in the newest archive, **P Pre-run setup**: switch on **11 Location folders** and **Bypass yes**.
4. **Cameras:** share one list: `cameras_file: ..\cameras.json` in each archive's `da-archive.yaml`, then `da cameras --detect` in each, and **C Cameras** to fill in owners, film cameras and their years.
5. **Backup:** with the backup drive plugged in, `da backup --setup E:\DA-backup` (its letter). Run the **Back up archives** shortcut it makes once.
6. **Shortcuts:** right-click, **Send to > Desktop (create shortcut)**, and rename: the newest archive's **Open DA.cmd** (Open DA), its `intake\photos` (New photos) and `intake\docs` (New papers), and the folder holding the archives (Archives).

7. Fill in **My archive** on the first page, print the cards, and do Card 1 and Card 3b together once.
